

Trainee Worksheet 4

Telephone English II: Managing Calls Professionally

✓ Learning goals

- Ask a caller to hold politely.
- Explain that someone is unavailable.
- Transfer a call or redirect the caller to the correct department.
- Offer to take a message or arrange a call back.
- Ask for repetition, spelling and confirmation when needed.
- Complete a message / transfer note accurately.



Key idea for today

When a call becomes difficult, pause, clarify, check and choose a simple professional action.

◆ Quick confidence check

Tick how you feel now. Be honest - this is only to help you learn.

I can...	Not yet	With help	Confident
ask a caller to hold	☐	☐	☐
say someone is unavailable politely	☐	☐	☐
transfer a call	☐	☐	☐
take a message when there is a problem	☐	☐	☐

Activity 1 - Phrase sorting: What should the receptionist do?

Work with a partner. Sort the phrases into the correct category. Then practise saying the phrases aloud.

Support tip

Do not translate word by word. Look for the action: hold, unavailable, transfer, message/call back.

A. I'll put you through to Finance.	B. Would you like him to call you back?	C. Just a moment, please.
D. She's out of the office today.	E. Can I take a message?	F. I'll transfer your call now.
G. Please hold while I check.	H. He's on another call at the moment.	I. I can ask her to call you back.
J. Thank you for holding.	K. I'm sorry, she's in a meeting.	L. Let me transfer you to the correct department.

2

Ask the caller to hold	Say someone is unavailable	Transfer the call	Offer message / call back
Write letters here: _____ _____ _____ Practise one phrase: _____	Write letters here: _____ _____ _____ Practise one phrase: _____	Write letters here: _____ _____ _____ Practise one phrase: _____	Write letters here: _____ _____ _____ Practise one phrase: _____

Extension challenge

Choose one phrase and make it softer or more professional. Example: "Wait." → "Just a moment, please."

Activity 2 - The call decision tree

Read the decision tree. Complete the missing actions using the words in the box.

WORD BOX: transfer | take a message | call back | clarify / repeat | correct department | confirm

Situation	What should the receptionist do?
The person is available.	_____ the call.
The person is not available.	Offer to _____ or arrange a _____.
The caller has the wrong department.	Send the caller to the _____.
The information is not clear.	Ask the caller to _____.
The caller leaves information.	Write a clear message and _____ before closing.

Model call - read and notice

Receptionist: Good morning. Administration Department. How can I help you?

Caller: Hello. I'd like to speak to Ms Costa, please.

Receptionist: Who's calling, please?

Caller: This is Daniel Martins from GreenLine Supplies.

Receptionist: Just a moment, please. I'll check.

Receptionist: Thank you for holding. I'm sorry, Ms Costa is in a meeting at the moment. Can I take a message?

Caller: Yes, please. Could you ask her to call me back about the delivery?

Receptionist: Of course. Could I have your number, please?

Caller: It's 912 456 783.

Receptionist: Let me repeat that: 912 456 783. Is that correct?

Caller: Yes, that's correct.

Receptionist: I'll pass on the message. Thank you for calling. Goodbye.

3

Underline in different colours or symbols:

- the phrase used to ask the caller to hold;
- the phrase used to say Ms Costa is unavailable;
- the phrase used to offer to take a message;
- the confirmation phrase;
- the closing phrase.

Activity 3 - Guided listening: What action is needed?

Your trainer will read four short calls. First, listen for the action only. Then listen again and add the key information.

Call	Transfer?	Take message?	Call back?	Wrong department?	Key information
1	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	
2	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	
3	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	
4	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	

Useful listening strategy

You do not need to understand every word. Listen for names, departments, phone numbers, and the action needed.

Activity 4 - Controlled speaking: call management practice

Work in pairs. Student A is the receptionist. Student B is the caller. Use the flow below and a caller card. Then swap roles.

Step	Useful language
1. Open	Good morning. Administration Department. How can I help you?
2. Identify	Who's calling, please? / What company are you calling from?
3. Ask reason	Who would you like to speak to? / What is the call about?
4. Manage	Just a moment, please. / I'll transfer your call. / Can I take a message?
5. Check	Could you repeat that, please? / Let me repeat that. / Is that correct?
6. Close	I'll pass on the message. Thank you for calling. Goodbye.

Message / transfer note

Caller	
Company	
Person / department needed	
Reason for call	
Action	
Phone number / extension	
Message	
Receptionist initials	

✂ Caller cards - Activity 4

Choose a card. Do not show your card to the receptionist.

Card 1 - Transfer You are Laura Mendes from Bright Office. You want to speak to the Finance Department. Reason: invoice 784. Extension: 305.	Card 2 - Unavailable person You are Peter Collins from West Travel. You want to speak to Ms Ferreira. She is not available. Message: Please call back about tomorrow's meeting. Phone: 213 556 908.
Card 3 - Wrong department You are Rita Gomes from Alpha Supplies. You are calling about a delivery. You called Administration, but you need Logistics. Phone: 934 221 700.	Card 4 - Call back You are Miguel Santos from NovaTech. You want to speak to Mr Costa. He is on another call. Message: Please call back today about contract documents. Phone: 912 700 445.
Card 5 - Urgent message You are Emma Clark from Blue River Hotel. You want to speak to the Office Manager. Reason: urgent booking change. Phone: 218 440 991. Ask for a call back this morning.	Card 6 - Unclear information You are André Silva from Porto Events. You want to speak to Ms Lopes. Reason: meeting room reservation. Phone: 915 330 208. Spell your surname when asked.
Card 7 - Transfer to HR You are Maria Costa from EasyPrint. You need the HR Department. Reason: training certificates. Extension: 402.	Card 8 - Changed number You are John Miller from GreenLine Supplies. You want to speak to Ms Costa. Reason: delivery confirmation. First give this number: 912 700 455. Then correct it: 912 700 445.

5

☎ Activity 5 - Back-to-back telephone challenge

Sit back-to-back with your partner. The receptionist cannot see the caller card. Ask, check, write down and confirm.

- Receptionist: use at least two checking phrases.
- Caller: speak naturally, but not too fast.
- At the end, compare the message / transfer note with the caller card.

Caller	_____
Company	_____
Person / department needed	_____
Reason for call	_____
Action needed	☐ Transfer ☐ Take message ☐ Call back ☐ Redirect ☐ Other: _____
Phone / extension	_____
Message	_____
Checking phrases used	☐ Could you repeat that? ☐ Could you spell that? ☐ Let me repeat that. ☐ Is that correct?
Final result	_____

Useful checking phrases

- Sorry, could you repeat that, please?
- Could you spell that, please?
- Could you speak more slowly, please?
- Let me repeat that.
- Is that correct?

Activity 6 - Read and repair

Some receptionist responses sound too direct or unclear. Rewrite them in a more professional way.

Too direct / unclear	Better professional version	What action is it?
Wait.	Just a moment, please.	hold
She isn't here.		
What?		
Wrong department.		
Call later.		
I don't know.		

Challenge

Add one more weak phrase and improve it.

Weak phrase	Professional version

★ Activity 7 - Final role-play: solve the call

Work in groups of 3: caller, receptionist and observer. Choose one scenario. Act out the call and complete the observer checklist.

Scenario A: The caller wants Finance, but has called Administration. The receptionist must redirect or transfer the call.

Scenario B: The caller wants Ms Costa, but she is in a meeting. The receptionist must take a message and arrange a call back.

Scenario C: The caller wants delivery information, but the receptionist needs to check. The receptionist must ask the caller to hold politely.

Scenario D: The caller has an urgent message for the Office Manager. The receptionist must collect details and confirm the action.

7

Did the receptionist...	Yes	Not yet
open the call professionally?	☐	☐
ask who was calling?	☐	☐
identify the reason for the call?	☐	☐
use a hold / transfer / message phrase?	☐	☐
ask for clarification when needed?	☐	☐
confirm the action?	☐	☐
close politely?	☐	☐

★ Useful phrase bank - keep this page!

Function	Useful phrases
Ask to hold	Just a moment, please. / Could you hold for a moment, please? / Please hold while I check. / Thank you for holding.
Unavailable	I'm sorry, she's not available at the moment. / He's in a meeting. / She's on another call. / He's out of the office today.
Transfer	I'll transfer your call now. / I'll put you through to Finance. / Let me transfer you to the correct department.
Offer message	Can I take a message? / Would you like to leave a message? / I can ask her to call you back.
Clarify/check	Could you repeat that, please? / Could you spell that? / Let me repeat that. / Is that correct?
Close	I'll pass on the message. / Thank you for calling. Goodbye.



✓ Exit ticket - quick reflection

Today I practised how to...	
One phrase for asking a caller to hold is...	
One phrase for saying someone is unavailable is...	
One phrase I want to remember is...	
I still need help with...	